

## “FOURS”



In my thirty two years, I never met one as charming, devoted or as loyal as Brownny. Everyone said I was lucky to have him and I looked forward to a very long and satisfying relationship with him.

The first day I met my Brownny, he was standing by a kiosk adjacent to my house, taking cover from the rain which had already drenched him. The honk of my car had startled him from where he was leaning against the wall and he stood at alert.

While I waited for Ken, the gateman to open the gate, I observed Brownny. He was peering into my car, looking directly at me, as if daring me to make a false move, so that he would bolt. As I drove by, entering the gate, I looked into his face, to get a better look, and that was when I noticed his eyes. They were the

colour of the roofs of the city of Ibadan. And I saw something else there, fright.

While unlocking the door to my apartment, I couldn't help but think of the poor creature alone, in the rain. I wasn't in the habit of opening my doors to strangers, but I felt I could make an exception, and so with a half convinced mind and unsure steps, I went out in the rain, and there he was, shivering. I talked to him, reassuring him and took him inside, to the warmth of my house, and called him 'Brown Sugar', which I shortened to 'Brownny'. That was the beginning of our beautiful love story.

Brownny became my lover, friend, and companion. He lighted up once I walked into the room, looking at me with those dreamy earth-brown eyes that attracted me that fateful day. As I was the only one with a job, I made sure he never lacked anything. His comfort and happiness were my priority.

It was a perfect relationship, until he fell sick with pneumonia. I was shocked and angry with myself that I missed the signs. I was always at work and he never let on any signs at those moments we shared between dinner, bed and breakfast. Dr. Chucks prescribed some drugs which we got and I prayed that he would get better.

It was on a Friday. I had just come back from work, and went into the house, expecting Brownny's warm welcome, instead, I found him laying on the floor, wheezing. I screamed and called Ken, the gateman. Ken came and saw me trying to lift Brownny. He helped me get him into my car, opened the gate, and I raced to the Clinic in a state between mad panic and cautiousness.

At the Clinic, Dr Chucks, who had already received my distress call, was waiting and helped me get Brownny out of the car, into the Clinic. I paced at the waiting area, praying for a miracle. A pang shot through my heart, and I rushed into the room where Dr. Chucks, another doctor, and Brownny, were.

Time froze immediately, and I seemed to be outside my body, watching Brownny's glazed eyes staring back at me, his body jerking in deathly spasms. I heard myself scream, horrified not so much at the inevitability of his end, as at his painful moribundity. I felt a hand on my shoulder and saw Dr. Chucks shake his head and mouth the words "lost him". I dashed to the gurney, shaking my head and Brownny vigorously, willing him to live, begging him with my heart to defy the doctor's words and return to me, till I was led away by the other doctor.

It has been more than three years now, and the void he left cannot be filled by any other dog. I still miss Brownny's bark, his tail wagging in excitement at seeing me. I miss running my hand through his rich golden fur and having him lick my face. I miss his companionship and most of all, I miss those Brown eyes that saw right through me and loved me unconditionally.



**THE END**

**CATEGORY: CREATIVE NON-FICTION**